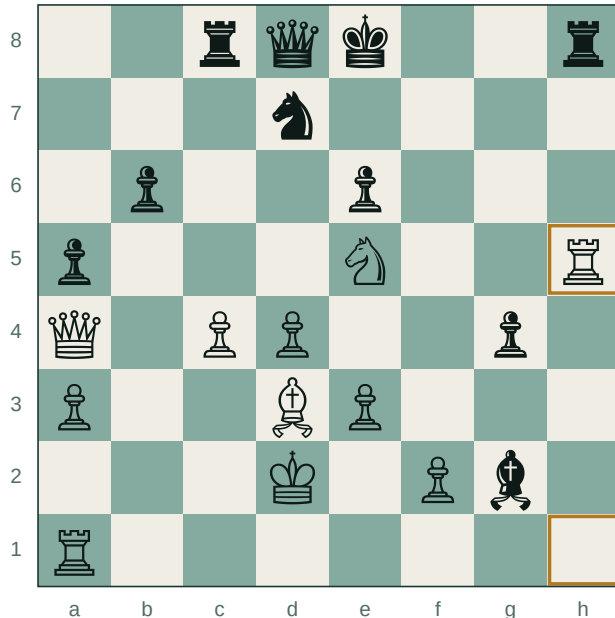


Loose-piece tactics: Black, move 22

Loose-piece tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 22.Rxh5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

22...Rxh5 23. Bg6+ Ke7 24. Qxd7+ Qxd7

22...Rxh5 The rook captures the rook on h5. Recorded reply: **23.Bg6+**.

23...Ke7 The king moves from e8 to e7. Recorded reply: **24.Qxd7+**.

24...Qxd7 The queen captures the queen on d7.

At the end, nominal material is White 16 / Black 26 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +11. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +11:** the balance goes from -1 to +10. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on d2. Geometrically undefended: rook on h5 and queen on a4. Check for tactical protection.